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Bob Haggart

Bassist Bob Haggart was one of the swing era's most notable instrumentalists and arrangers and is still a major player in today's classic jazz scene. Born in New York City in 1914, he first came to prominence in 1935 with the Bob Crosby Orchestra. His bass playing and writing skills were a major contribution to the success of the Crosby group and his composition for bass and drums, "Big Noise from Winnetka" became a signature tune for the band. Haggart later co-led the World's Greatest Jazz Band, worked in the radio and jingle market and wrote some enduring standards, including "What's New." He continues to appear at jazz festivals and parties and lends his arranging skills to such projects as Kenny Davern's album with strings, "My Inspiration."

Bob was interviewed on September 22, 1995 at Hamilton College by Dr. Michael Woods. Pianist Ralph Sutton was also present at the interview.

MW: The Hamilton College Jazz Archive are filming interviews with some of America's greatest jazz musicians. We're fortunate to have with us today Bob Haggart. Pleased to be with you.

BH: Thank you.

MW: You are a stellar bassist. When did you start playing the string bass, and what led you to that instrument?

BH: Well I was, I started playing in high school actually. But before that I was a guitar player and played the special tuning, they don't use it today, it's a four string instrument with a tenor banjo tuning and then the strings were inverted so that the bottom string was up an octave and the top string was down an octave, which made it more like a ukulele in other words, close tuning. And I studied with George VanEps at that time, who is, he was playing that particular instrument and starting on the regular six string guitar at that time. So we played duets. That's a long story. I wasn't even thinking of bass at that time, although my two favorite bass players were Pops Foster, played with Luis Russell's band, and Artie Bernstein, who I happened to hear along about that time. He had just switched from cello and he tuned his bass in fifths, which I had never heard of that before. I was just learning how to. In high school I just picked up the bass, of course tuned in fourths, as it still is. But in fifths means it's like the cello, C-G-D-A, and the same as tenor banjo tuning too, which only would be up an octave with the banjo of course. But Artie Bernstein got such a marvelous sound out of his instrument, and being a beginner on the bass, I was very impressed with that. And of course I would go into Roseland and hear Pops Foster playing with Luis Russell's band and he was like the star of the band. He got

both of those guys. In those days bass was sort of part of the rhythm section and you never heard from them hardly any solos. The only who was playing solos in those days was Milt Hinton with Cab Calloway's band, and Milt, he was the first really well known bassist, outside of perhaps Red Brown, who played with the Goldkette band, Steve Brown, called Steve "Red" Brown. He joined after Jean Goldkette, he went with Paul Whiteman. And that was the first recording where you could really hear the bass. Up to that time there were mostly tubas. Bass players hadn't started switching over from tuba to string bass. I'm talking about 1928, 1929.

MW: That's what I was going to ask about, when they made the switch.

BH: That's right.

MW: Was there a time when you were expected to play both?

BH: Oh, yeah. They'd say, "Bring both." You'd bring them both on the job. Imagine bringing a tuba and a string bass both. There's a guy today that, Vince Giordano, who plays the bass sax, and he brings all three. Not only that, he sets up the music stands and microphones, a PA system, plus bringing his three instruments, the string bass, the bass saxophone and a tuba. And the poor guy is very discouraged. He's in New York but he can't get much work for his band, and I know he's thinking of chucking the whole thing. But he's playing music of the '20s and '30s, and these are all young guys. And it's really a kick to hear those arrangements which he makes and he has a couple of other arrangers in the band. They are all New York musicians and they're all young, and they're all playing the music they played back then. They're not playing any kind of rock & roll or anything like that, they're not playing bebop, they're just playing— and there's this whole gang of good players that know all the old songs, and play jazz the way Ralph and I play it. You know, they play those same tunes.

MW: Do you think that's trying to send a —

BH: They're sort of carrying it on, you know, and we're very lucky to have those guys, I'm talking about Dan Barrett and Jon-Erik Kellso, and Howard Alden on the guitar. These guys are all in their — Harry Allen, tenor sax, Ken Peplowski. They're all getting a name for themselves as they're marvelous players, and they're not playing bebop. They're going earlier than bebop. In other words, it's like swing — classic jazz, as they say.

MW: About the swing era, people say that this is the era when America was dancing.

BH: That's true, yeah.

MW: How did playing bass —

BH: Nobody had any money and it was the cheapest way to have a date. You'd go out to take your girl to the dance and have a little flask on your hip, you know, a jug, and for seventy-five cents, that's all it cost to go in and dance for the evening. Of course the

cash. And so that was the thing to do was to go out and dance. It was very exciting in those days. The bands were good and there were thousands of them on the road playing in these dance halls, which are all torn down now. But every amusement park had a big ballroom, and every hotel, and of course the theaters featured bands that played on the stage and accompanied all the acts that would come like Señor Wences and the dog acts and the jugglers, and dance teams, and four or five different acts would go on in front of the band. The band would play all the music. They called those "presentation houses" didn't they, Ralph? That was before Ralph's time.

RS: Way before my time.

MW: How did playing bass in those ensembles, how did it give you an education that perhaps you don't get in a university now?

BH: Well I think they had, they ask the question, how do you learn how to do that? Well I found it's mostly from listening. You have to have it up here. You have to want to do it. And by listening to records, and listening to other players or groups live, in those days we listened to records all the time. So you'd memorize, you'd hear a guy play a chorus, and you'd play it over so many times you knew it note for note, you could sing it. Like all Louis Armstrong's early records. I could sing every note right now. You have it in your head. Your head's like a computer, you know, you remember. You remember everything that you like. I could remember all Jack Teagarden's solos because he was my hero, Jack was. Jack, Bud Freeman, Louis Armstrong, Benny Goodman. These were all names that I had every one of their records and I could sing you any chorus that they did on any tune. So you have to have it inside, you see, and then another thing that's important is the time, learning how to keep time. You keep it steady, don't rush, don't drag, get it in a groove.

MW: Do you think that sometimes even between the bass and the drums that the drummer actually wants you to take the time?

BH: Well, that's a very moot point, you know, it's very, there's none of that after you, because by the time you do that you're behind. In other words, you both have to feel the same way, and you both know it when it's happening, it gets good. It's like life, you know, I mean a lot of things have a mutual feeling between you, and this goes for the whole band has the same feeling of the beat, and that has to be, well, it just happens automatically. You don't have to think about it. It's just a happy feeling and when you're in it you know it but you don't plan it that way it just happens. It's hard to put to words because it's just a feeling. It's a good feeling when the band in swinging. You can't teach it. You can't teach how to swing. It's what they say about golf. Golf is a game you can teach but you can't learn.

MW: [laughs] That's a good one.

MW: On that same note —

BH: I think the same thing holds true with jazz. You could try to teach it but you can't learn it unless you want to, I mean, you have to like something that you hear and say "sheez, I'd like to do that, I want to play like that." And it will get you started. And then you get your own thing going. You do what you're feeling. It comes to you and you can't go wrong copying somebody else. That's the mistake a lot of guys make. They want to play like Benny Goodman, they wind up playing like Benny Goodman and they don't have anything to say of their own. It goes for any instrument, you know. But you have to start someplace.

MW: So, it's good to have someone to at least be interested in.

BH: Sure. A role model, is that what they call it? Yeah. It's a good thing, I think. I don't know how else you can get started.

MW: Is there an art to constructing a good bass line?

BH: What?

MW: Is there an art to constructing a good bass line?

BH: Well, I've written a bass method book that's out of print, and has been for a long time, but Ray Brown studied out of my book, and when I met Ray Brown he was playing with Dizzy Gillespie's big band on 52nd street. And I think it was the first time Ray Brown had ever been to New York. I don't know were he's from originally, but he was a marvelous player at that time. He was about eighteen years old. And he came over to the table and my wife and I were there listening to Louis', uh, Dizzy's big band, and Ray Brown said, "I studied out of your book, Mr. Haggart." He called me Mr. Haggart. I said, "I better go take another look at that book, I must have missed something." Because he was playing all over that bass, stuff that he never found in that book, that's for sure. So but you can't really learn to play out of books I don't think. I think it's good to get you started, find out where the notes are so that when the time comes and you have to read a bass part. You seldom read what's there anyway, you have to use your ear and play what you think it should be. As long as you know what chords are happening, and the way the tune is constructed, those are things you learn when you're a kid you see, how to train your ear and to remember chord sequences. You have to store all those tunes in your head so that when they call out a tune you can't say, "I don't know it, what else do you know, what else?" And then you say, "Well I don't know that either—what else?" You've got to know everything. If you're going to play in a band you have to know every tune. I don't know how you do that. It's just something that takes a long time. Now these kids today, they know all those tunes, the ones I mentioned before, you know? Howard Alden, he's got some kind of a brain because he not only remembers the tunes but he remembers all

unison lines exactly like Lester Young did in 1935, you know? It's possible to store all kinds of information in your head I'm told. But I could never do that.

MW: Tell us about, a little bit about the transition from the Pollack band to the Crosby band.

BH: The Pollack band? Ben Pollack? Well that's what happened. The Ben Pollack guys all left him because they weren't getting any work. He was trying to get his wife, who was the girl singer, he was trying to get her into pictures. And so the band had these long layoffs and they got sick and tired of waiting around to work. So they finally discussed it with the girl singer, Doris Robbins, and they left California and went to New York and stuck together and rehearsed and did some recording dates and looked around for a leader, a new leader. So they wanted Jack Teagarden, but they couldn't get him because he was signed up with Paul Whiteman at that time. So they came across, somebody suggested Bob Crosby would be a good choice because of his brother Bing being so famous, people would want to see what his kid brother looked like. And so we went on the road in 1935 and we did big business, always did, because of the name. And the band happened to be damn good, you know? So we formed a corporation and I was asked, I was the only non-Pollack guy, I just joined after. I never was with Pollack. But they let me come in too, so I was a member of the corporation. But the problem there was that the guys that weren't in the corporation, it made it kind of sticky because they felt like second class citizens you know? Actually they were making more money than the guys in the corporation, because we had expenses that came out first and so there was never any kind of split, we were just on a salary and that was it. The corporation never meant anything. It was just that we'd have a meeting once in a while and we'd sit around listening to Gil Rodin talk. That was about it. Gil Rodin was really the guy who was really the brains behind the Pollack band too. He played lead alto and he was the businessman in the crowd. He could have been a lawyer I think, but he used to handle all the song pluggers and the bookers and so he really ran the band, because Bob Crosby knew nothing about that. So without Gil Rodin it wouldn't have stuck together very long I'm afraid. But he kept everybody feeling optimistic and he'd make all the promises to everybody when they'd come in the band, and make sure they were happy with how much money they were going to make. So Gil Rodin was the brains behind the whole thing.

MW: In other words, playing the music and the way that music actually interfaces with the music world can be two different things, can't it? In other words there's the actual playing of the music and then there's the business end of it.

BH: Oh, sure I guess, I never paid any attention to the business end of it myself. I was only interested in, I did a lot of arranging, and I was up almost every night until three or four

played, two days later you could hear the live thing. The guys reading the notes and playing. That was the biggest kick right there.

MW: I was going to ask you about that.

BH: That was a payoff, because, then the night after that it would be on the radio. So and then they'd record it. They recorded almost everything. All the fad tunes, and there's 5-6 pages in *Discography* of the Bob Crosby band, and there are all these tunes, ninety percent of them you never heard of because they weren't hits, they were just these things the song pluggers would give us the song copies and said, "Here" and paid me $35.00 to do the arrangement. That was the only time I ever got paid was from the song publisher, plugger they called them, song pluggers.

MW: Tell us a couple of your favorite arrangements that the band played.

BH: Well I guess the most famous was "South Rampart Street Parade." That's the one that's played most today. They made a stock orchestration out of it. And so that got around. It's a New Orleans march, you know, which isn't everybody's dish of tea to play a New Orleans march because it's not exactly a thing for dancing but even Guy Lombardo, that was his big number. He'd play "South Rampart Street Parade," with Guy Lombardo and they'd get hot on it. But you know that's not a jazz band. Lombardo was a very sweet, they called it "sweet music" in those days. There was "hot music" and there was "sweet music." And this had a nice tempo and everything, and then all the old people loved to dance to Guy Lombardo. It's like Lawrence Welk today. He was the Lawrence Welk of those days, Guy Lombardo. "Sweetest music this side of heaven" that was their logo. Ours was "the greatest Dixieland band in the land," the Bob Crosby band.

MW: And you made arrangements also for the smaller group that played out of that?

BH: Well, we didn't have arrangements for the Bob Cats, that was strictly head arrangements, faked you know. Figure out a little introduction or something sometimes, and we'd just talk over it the first time we'd run it down, we'd say you do this and I'll take sixteen, then Eddie will play eight, then we'll play stops, then we'll play drum breaks, and you know, you'd talk it over. You don't have any music. Well that's the way we are this thing we're doing this weekend. We don't have music. We just pick out some songs and whatever Kenny wants to play we play. Right? Kenny picks the tunes usually, and Warren goes along with anything.

MW: If you were explaining to students that you knew were going to see this tape, could you explain to them how much vocabulary a jazz musician has to bring to the table in order to do that, in order to have guys, maybe he's never played with just call tunes and be able to make it through those tunes.

BH: Well that's, it takes a long time I guess to learn enough songs to learn all those old songs.

tune that everybody knows, I mean everybody in the band, even the bass player, all right? The bass player is supposed to know everything. You can't say I don't know it, because I never say I don't know anything, I just shut up and wait and listen, wait and see. I kind of cool it in the beginning and sometimes the piano will go like this, for a two chord or four chord or something. F, G#, you know, so you fake it. You've got to be a faker to play bass. Pretend, you know?

MW: And then the second chorus you come out cooking. After you've got it.

BH: Second chorus you've forgotten what you did the first chorus. Yeah. Well, you have to store up all these tunes in your head. You have to like it. You've got to like those songs. Irving Berlin, you know how many songs Irving Berlin wrote? More than anybody. I think I know them all, just because I was around when they came out, a lot of them. Even "Alexander's Ragtime Band" that was way before my time but you learned that right away, you know. It's a very simple song. Any fool can play it though [hums]. 1-4-5, it's all based on. The rock & roll has those three chords, 1, 4 and 5. You learn those three chords you can play almost anything, until you get into Cole Porter. George Gershwin gets a little more, you know, Harold Arlen, it gets a little more sophisticated and you've got to learn all those other little side turns. Jerome Kern, "The Song Is You." I mean it separates the men from the boys when you learn the release to "The Song Is You," it goes into all kinds of strange levels, you know? You start in C and then you go into E and you go into G# minor and, you know. So it helps to study all those chords. Study harmony. Study composition, the way chords are constructed. Bass lines, and the little cello line. The melody and the bass line, and then one other line inside there, the tune is constructed on those three lines. The melody and the bass, even in Beethoven or Bach, that's still a fundamental that goes through any music. You have the melody and then have the bass, and then you have all the stuff in between, that's just the icing on the cake. But the fundamental thing is the bass line and the melody. Am I making any sense at all?

MW: You're making wonderful sense, because I feel that the two of those are the most active of the lines—

BH: True.

MW: And sometimes I feel it's the bass player's job to put enough curve on the bottom of the band to make a soloist work. Because if a bass player plays flat and doesn't play any energy—

BH: No help at all.

MW: He doesn't feed the soloist anything.

BH: No help, that's right. And you've got to watch out for the piano player's left hand, too. Because you've got to deal with that. So you've got to, you know, you've got to work

speed up or the drum sets a nice groove and the bass player is right together and the thing is swinging, and the front line automatically has to fall in that groove, you know. So you're there to help. The bass player is there to help that's for sure. Yeah. You can press a little bit, that helps sometimes, so it doesn't start going backwards.

MW: Right, right.

BH: You've got to lean on it sometimes. And sometimes you've got to kind of hold it back. It's not like a metronome. It doesn't have to be like a metronome. It depends on what the tune is and what's happening. Sometimes it wants to move, you know?

MW: Sometimes too much precision can stop it from swinging, if it's rigid.

BH: You listen to the Basie band. They used to lean so far back you thought they were going to — they're not slowing down but it seems like it. Some of those real slow things you know? It's very hard to play slow and keep it swinging.

MW: Because the tone is so exposed.

BH: Yeah.

MW: I want to ask you something about playing the bass and playing slowly. Because a string bass, unlike amplified bass guitar, you only have your physical enunciation of the string. And obviously no matter how hard you hit it there's a certain amount of decay in between notes. But it's the sustain of the notes that drives it. So that has to be a lot of your particular technique to keep a band so instead of playing notes — thud-thud-thud, you play a phrase — ka-toom-toom-toom.

BH: That's right, you have to. You have to preface the notes with little lead-ins, especially when it's real slow — te-te-te-bamm — or a little da-dit-en-dit-en-duh. You can do triplets, you could do sixteenths, you could do something. As long as the downbeats are where they're supposed to be.

MW: You have to nail it down.

BH: That's right. You're swinging them all slowly, you've got to swing, because you're beating double time anyway, if you're playing very slow you're sort of beating in twelve you know, you think in twelve. Four sets of sixteenths. So it's really double time, but you don't play double time, you think double time. Or else you think in triplets. So it's back and forth, you know. I don't know whether that makes sense or not.

MW: Yeah, it makes plenty of sense. Tell us about some of your time in Europe with what was called The World's Greatest Jazz Band.

BH: Milton. We did quite a few trips with the World's Greatest Jazz Band. And I've been over since then too with a lot of the same guys, Kenny Davern and Yank Lawson and George Masso, and Ralph Sutton, and Jake Hanna. But we've been over every times it seems it's a slightly different group. You hardly ever go over with exactly the same

really seem to love jazz. They won't let you off the stage, you've got to play two encores anyway at the end of a set, and sometimes three, and they get their feet stomping. Clap-stomp at the same time, and that means get ready to play another one. But you've got to pretend. You walk off the stage and you wait out there and then say, "Guess we're going to do another one," and start ambling back on again. You play a second one, and it starts over again. They don't do that over here. I mean there's something about Europe, it's not just Germany, I mean they do the same thing I think in Scotland and in Scandinavia, in Stockholm.

MW: Do you feel the appreciation is greater, and if so why?

BH: I guess it's because they've gotten it through just recordings. And when you come over in person they're very thrilled. And they have all these records and they want you to autograph the records and they come in with a pile of records like that, and a lot of this stuff came out in Europe and you didn't even know they existed. Of course you never see any royalties, that's for sure. Things come out. So you sign a whole bunch of these things and it's really an ego trip because you didn't realize that people cared, you know? But over there they seem to. You feel like you're a hero when you go over there. Now like Jerry Jerome has never been over there, and there's a guy who's made records with Glenn Miller and Benny Goodman, and Artie Shaw. And he's never been to Europe. He went over for the first time to Holland and found out all these people knew who Jerry Jerome was because they were avid record collectors, you know? They don't miss a thing. You certainly don't see much of that over here.

MW: Is there anything we can do to kind of create that respect for this art form, right here in the United States?

BH: Gee, I wish I could answer that one. But you're doing what you can by having these archives and trying to expose the kids to letting them hear some of the stuff live. I've been playing a few elementary schools and high schools and little kids love it. It's amazing how little kids, first graders, second graders, third graders, they come in and they just get so excited. They jump all around you know, and if you could get them at that age, that's—but how you going to do it, because there aren't enough musicians around that are left, you know they're all dying off, the ones who played swing, the style we play. There's just a handful of guys as I mentioned before, that are in their 30s, 20s, 30s, 40s, you know, Dan Barrett, Jon-Erik Kellso, Randy Sandke, Harry Allen. Now there are a lot more than that, but they happen to be the ones that I've been working with lately. But there are young guys that are marvelous players that, well, they wind up teaching school because there aren't enough places to play. You can't make a living. It's a sad state of affairs, because when we started out, there were all kinds of little joints you could

play. You've got to have places where you can be lousy, to start. And in those days, you could. You could play rotten and they thought it was marvelous.

MW: I wanted to ask you something that I'd like to relate to our students. You know, many times people didn't understand how necessary jam sessions were but that's where you could work out your ideas. Tell us about jam sessions.

BH: We used to do quite a lot of that, get together and play. I know that when I was just learning the bass we'd go into the auditorium when nothing was happening, go down to the bottom of the auditorium there and this trombone player and I would play tunes. He was just learning "Jazz Me Blues" and tunes like that, and I was just learning the bass, I had just learned the scale. So I was learning to play in B flat. He showed me the C scale. And then I went from there, the first Saturday night I got a job on the bass, right away, made eight bucks. I don't know what I was doing, but it was fun, and so that started me off. But you have to get together. When I hear kids say how do you do this, what do you — I say well you find a guy who likes to play and the two of you get together and get a third guy, and you try to play songs, you play tunes. Let's try to play this, you know, and you all listen to records, and that's the way it happened with me anyway, it's — all like the same things. I was crazy about Bud Freeman and I first heard Red Nichols and his Five Pennies with Jimmy Dorsey on the clarinet, and then I heard Benny Goodman for God's sake, he was unbelievable in those days, way out front in a class by himself. He was just a kid in his 20s. And Jack Teagarden, I couldn't believe, before that it was Miff Mole, he was around New York and Jack came in to town and turned it all around, Teagarden. Bud Freeman, on the tenor sax, and Coleman Hawkins, he and Coleman Hawkins were the two stars at that time. Later Lester Young you know, Chu Berry, Coltrane. Everything goes in stages, you know.

MW: Is there anybody today that is playing the bass the way that you like to hear it played?

BH: Well, Milt Hinton has been my role model for a long time. I always wanted to— And then there are a lot of young players doing things on the bass we never dreamed of back in the 30s — Scott LaFaro was the first one, have you ever heard of him? He died young. Oh, there are all kinds of wonderful bass players too numerous to mention that are doing things on the bass that have taken the bass out of just being part of the rhythm section instead of being a solo instrument. But unfortunately most of the guys are playing solo when they're supposed to be playing in the rhythm section. And they're jumping all over everybody else's lines. In other words instead of playing in a rhythm section and just laying low, you know, you can't be a comedian all you life, you have to let someone else — you always want to say "listen to me, listen to me," and it's like too many comedians. So the bass player that's all over the bass all the time, it's funny, you don't listen to him

play time, lay out once in a while. Don't try to prove, show your technique all the time. I think that's a mistake.

MW: So there's a specific role that the bass plays.

BH: Yes. He's supposed to be an accompaniment. It's an accompaniment instrument. Once in a while I get a chance to solo, that's great, but you don't solo in every tune. I think what started that is all the duos — the piano and bass — because the clubs couldn't afford any more than two men, and they wanted some kind of entertainment in a bar to attract people, so they'd get a very good piano player and he gets the best bass player he likes to work with. Piano and bass duos — like Ray Brown and Oscar Peterson. Start there. And then all over the world there's these piano and bass duos, no drums, can't afford it. Then there was Bill Evans, he always had marvelous bass players, he had Scott LaFaro, and they always had a quiet drummer. And that was it, the trio. You don't find many piano and guitar trios, because they duplicate each other and they have to give in to each other all the time. They have to work out things together in order to have, you know—

MW: To be compatible?

BH: Yeah, to be compatible, so they have to agree on things, then they have to give to each other all the time, decide on which chord to use here and there. The guitar player has got to keep his ears open, and the piano — It's much harder to play with piano and guitar then it is with just piano, bass and drums. Because that way nobody has to worry about anything, you know, they just play, and that's it.

MW: Each person has a distinctive register —

BH: A role, yes.

MW: I wanted to ask you, as we kind of wrap up our interview if you have some words of wisdom to pass on to young musicians who are just now beginning to come in to either study jazz as a performer, or taking a class in music appreciation involving jazz. What could you tell them about this idiom that you've experienced that you think is rich?

BH: I think I've already said it in that the secret I think is to get it up in your head and do a lot of listening. Listen to things that you like, and store up all these songs. If you want to be a performer and play with other guys, you have to spend a lot of time together, and both like the same things and learn the same things. And if you write original tunes, teach them to each other and you'll work out an act, just like the rock groups, that's the way they start they get together and the piano player will write some kind of a thing and they'll all learn it. And it's mostly vocal, it's all vocal things in rock. But there's hardly any vocal things in the kind of jazz we're doing. It doesn't have to be all vocal. It can be instrumental and there's all kind of combinations of instruments you can write for. You can have a flute and a cello and a clarinet and write jazz for that. But actually it doesn't

instruments doesn't really send you. A jazz flute to me doesn't have an awful lot of impact like a tenor saxophone, you know. And I prefer the lower instruments like trombone and tenor rather than the high clarinets and high note trumpet players, you know. All together they sound good, but if you just have a band of three trumpets and a rhythm section, what are you going to do? It's like a string quartet, you have the first violin, second viola and cello. And everybody's got their lines. Nobody interferes. So you've got a baritone sax, maybe a trombone, and an alto and a trumpet, or there's all kinds of combinations you could have. Usually one trumpet, one trombone, a tenor and a clarinet, that's what we usually have. That seems to work pretty good.

MW: That covers the register.

BH: Yeah, it's like four voices. And they don't get in each other's way too much. And again if those guys are going to play they've got to listen to each other. Don't try to make it, as Bobby Hackett says, "You don't try to make a home run every time, just get on base."

MW: That's a good one.

BH: Because a lot of guys think they have to show off everything they got in eight bars. You've got to lay out and listen, and then play something, then fit it in. You don't have to make a prove of what you can do, all at once. In other words, relax and go along for the ride and have a good time. Enjoy the music. Smell the flowers.

MW: Tell us about how'd you feel when you got this award, Jazzman of the Year?

BH: You mean out in California?

MW: Uh huh.

BH: I got there and I didn't even know about it. And somebody said, "Have you seen your picture on the cover?" They have a little booklet they pass around, you know, tells you where the bands are playing and everything. I'm on the cover. Nobody said, nobody even told me about that. Well the year before I'd had a big birthday party, eightieth birthday, and it had my picture on the cover of that too. So I started to get used to it. Well it's very exciting, you know. But I think what am I going to have to do, are they going to ask me questions in an interview or something? I never — always shy away from talking on microphones and things like that, but once I get started you can't stop me, that's the trouble. Ask me a simple question and you get a very involved answer.

MW: Well that's your prerogative, you've earned that. One last thing. Tell us about this piece, the "Big Noise"—

BH: Big noise?

MW: "Big Noise from Winnetka."

BH: Well I've been doing it, let's see 1939 is when it first happened. I got bitten by this big noise thing in 1939 it was actually. We were in Chicago with the Bob Crosby band and

He was the whole show and you'd go hear the show and you'd remember him because the way he played the drums, he was an act in himself. Wonderful. He could dance. But we were doing a number for the kids from Winnetka. There were a lot of kids from, it was a suburb of Chicago. The kids were in there to hear the band on a Sunday afternoon and we had a radio broadcast coming up as I remember it was at 5:00. And we used to put on a show for the kids with the small band, come down off the stand and had trumpet, trombone, clarinet, tenor, it was Yank Lawson and then Eddie Miller and Matty Matlock and Smitty. And they'd pull out a little upright piano for Bob Zerke and another set of drums for Ray Bauduc would slide out on a little dolly on the dance floor, and I'd bring my bass down. And we'd play three or four tunes, and the kids all sat on the dance floor. Bob Crosby would say, "Now everybody sit down." And this one day he said, "Well here's Ray Bauduc and Bobby Hackett and they're going to do the 'Big Noise from Winnetka.'" So we just went into something, made it up as we went along, because we had some time to kill before going on the radio, see. And we had just done a thing called the "Big Crash from China." That was the drum solo we used to play, something written by Ray Bauduc and with the Bobcats. And he played a lot of stuff with a big Chinese crash cymbal at the end, "Big Crash from China." And so here's the "Big Noise from Winnetka." He just made up the title, see, and so we made up something to go with it. And then the next week we went into the studio to do an album and we said, "What did we do the other day — we've got to do that number." So we tried to remember what we did. The gimmick is he plays on the G string of the bass with his sticks — tic-a-tic-a-tic-a-tic-a — and then I'd play up and down — ding-a-ding-a-ding-a-ding-a-ding-a-ding-a — and that was the gimmick.

MW: Did it ever get, finally get written down?

BH: Well I've written it out for people, yeah. In fact there's a guy that contacted me, wanted to make an arrangement for his, he had a girl band. And I forget the name of his band but it's a new group. They were all women. And they have a terrific bass player and they do "Big Noise," but they don't do it like I did it. They have their own way of doing it and it's a lot of stuff, and it starts off with the sticks on the bass, and then there's sticks on the guitar, and then on the tom tom. It's all percussive, the whole thing. And it's terrific. He sent me the tape of this thing. But he said would I send him a lead sheet of just the way I did it so I sent him a lead sheet. There's a regular melody to it, you know [humms]. It goes on and on and different parts to it. So she said that the girl bass player's going to make an arrangement for the whole band and it's very, supposed to be very exciting and everything, you know a lot of high trumpets. I'm anxious to hear it. So that's—that thing just stays alive, getting people. You keep hearing it in commercials. It was just in a

Hardee's commercial, you know the Hardee's Restaurant chain? And so I got a nice fat check for that.

MW: Doesn't it feel good to finally get some royalties?

BH: Oh, yeah.

MW: Finally get some of your due there.

BH: Well, like Linda Rondstadt's record of "What's New." That was a pretty nice, talking about money. It sold over 2 million. I'm one of the writers of "What's New." So that came in handy, too. Sounds like I'm bragging, doesn't it?

MW: Isn't it good to write something or do something that you know communicates to other musicians, even in other genres? That should make you feel good.

BH: It does but that happens after the fact. I mean when you're writing it you're not thinking of that, you're just doing something that you like that appeals to you. You write it out and did an arrangement for the band, that's the kick, when you hear it back the first time. And then as it goes on it gets better because they play it better. They learn it and everybody seems to fit their part and get it to blend better and everything's smoother. So that's the thing about arranging for a band. You see it evolve and get better as it goes, as it's played. But the very first hearing may have spots in there that are a disappointment to you as well, you know, it works two ways, and you fix it. You take it out or something, you fix something. Whatever it needs. That's what, they say Glenn Miller was very good at that — that was one of the best things he did was be able to doctor up arrangements. Of course he was a good writer himself, but, and Artie Shaw was very smart at fixing arrangements too. He could just make one little change — and Benny Goodman and Tommy Dorsey. They were all very good at fixing arrangements that weren't quite right, so they had to make little cuts or repeats, or changes of volume or whatever, you know. Tommy Dorsey was, according to Yank Lawson, and a lot of guys that played in the band said that Tommy was probably the best band leader. He was able to get the most out of the arrangements, and of course Glenn Miller's arrangements have lived longer than any of the others and there are more of them. Those were mostly Jerry Gray's arrangements. And they were all very well written. Things like [humms] "In the Mood." It's probably the most popular arrangement out of the whole Glenn Miller thing is "In the Mood." And it's kind of, I know one of the guys in the band was Al Klink and he hated that "In the Mood" so much that you wouldn't believe it. See he and Tex Beneke split the tenor solos on that record, it's four and four all the way through you know. Four Al Klink and four Tex Beneke, back to Al Klink, and back to Tex Beneke. They did a lot of take fours, and still do that today. So Al Klink, to his dying day, he just died a couple of years ago, that was one of his big hatreds that tune. You have to do it all the time, doesn't mean you

MW: And of course, you know, all bands have a tendency to be stereotyped for one or two favorite tunes and sometimes it isn't even the best tune.

BH: That's right. Like the Crosby band had the "South Rampart Street Parade." We always had to play it wherever he went, you know. Crosby himself became a band leader and he'd go around to different parts of the country and get all the local guys. He'd call ahead and some guy would contract the whole band: a sax section, a trumpet section, trombones, and rhythm. And he'd just go in with his arrangements, pass out the arrangements, and they'd rehearse and then he'd do his concert. And lots of times the local musicians were not necessarily real good but you didn't have to be that good if you're just playing in a section. You don't have to be a soloist. And I think that's the way it is with a lot of the kid bands today. You know you used to call them stage bands, you've got four trumpets, four trombones, five saxes. And there's an awful lot of music written for that kind of combination. The problem being is when you come right down to the solos, when there's a top tenor solo in there some place, who's going to play it, and is he ready for that? Because a lot of guys can play in the section and you don't have to be that good to play a solo.

MW: Because they can read it.

BH: They can read the part.

MW: They can read the part and they've got a little bit of the feel.

BH: The band sounds good. The only part that sounds a little weak is when they come to the solos. And that's the part that the guy with the good solo is going to get a job in real life and is going to go out and get on the road, if he's real good. Trumpet, trombone, tenor sax, those are the three big solo instruments, you know, the horns. The clarinet is something that it's pretty hard to find good clarinet players today, with the kids. It's a very difficult instrument, hard too. So — what was that question again?

MW: You've answered it, you answered it quite well. Tell us a little bit about the type of music and the setting in which you're going to perform a couple of times this weekend.

BH: What we're going to do this weekend?

MW: So that people will know some of your favorite styles, and your favorite songs, and some of the settings that you like to perform in. Because this is one of — the fact that we're doing an archive here is our way of trying to help preserve and perpetuate what we feel is a great art form, and then we're very grateful to have the performances this weekend, as part of that.

BH: Well we're just going to play, we don't know what we're going to play right now. We don't rehearse, we just decide on what we're going to open with, what's going to be second, and what's going to be third. We'll have a little list. And somebody'll play a solo

play a closer. By that time an hour is up. Opener, couple of tunes in the middle and a closer, and then you feature each guy on a tune. And the closer is usually an up tune. And that usually tops everything that's happened up to that point. It's more exciting, get a faster tempo going. And that's the general format. You don't end with a ballad. But you play ballads inside. You have to have change of pace. You know you don't play the same tempo twice in a row. Start with a middleing size tune, then maybe play something faster than that second, third you go way down slow and play a blues, and then play something in the middle again, then maybe a ballad, and then you play a closer. And then maybe do an encore, maybe — could be anything. So that's the format. That's usually the way we all work, and you just decide ahead of time what tunes you want to play. Everybody has to feel good about it. You say, "What do you want to do for a solo." "Oh, I'll do — whatever." I'll let you know later. You can't necessarily — it's no big deal, you don't have to let them know just what you're going to play. You think about it and when the time comes you say, "What are you going to do?" So, "Well what do YOU want to do." You can't do that. You've got to make up your mind and when the time comes you just do it. You can't hem and haw. So you have three or four things in your mind and if you decide at the last minute it's all right, who cares? As long as you finally make up your mind to do it.

MW: Right. I like that kind of spontaneity. We'll we've had a wonderful time interviewing here with Bob Haggart and we hope that many of our Hamilton College students and other students around the country will see these interviews and appreciate this great art form.

BH: Thank you. Glad to be here.